EMMA ZHENG'S EARLY AUTISM AWARENESS PROJECT

Autism Early Intervention Awareness

BILINGUAL RESOURCE GUIDE · ENGLISH EDITION



Empowering Chinese-speaking families with bilingual screening resources, developmental warning signs, and step-by-step pathways to local support services.

Visit: emmaz-sv.github.io/early-autism-awareness

Contact: ezhengva@gmail.com

MILESTONES & WARNING SIGNS

Early Signs & Developmental Red Flags

Autism can be reliably identified as early as 18–24 months. Recognizing warning signs allows parents to access intervention services during the most critical periods of brain development.

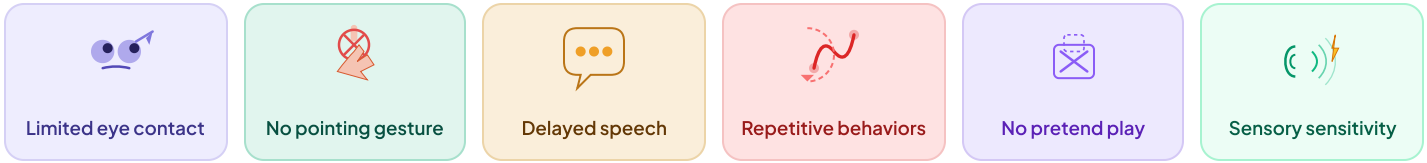
1 Social & Communication

- **No response to name** by 12 months — often mistaken for hearing issues.
- **Lack of joint attention** — doesn't point to show interest by 18 months, or look when you point.
- **No sharing of interests** — doesn't bring toys to share excitement by 15 months.
- **No imitation** of actions, sounds, or expressions by 18 months.
- **No interactive play** — no peek-a-boo or waving bye-bye by 12 months.

2 Play & Behavioral Patterns

- **No pretend play** — doesn't pretend to feed a doll or push a block like a car by 18–24 months.
- **Repetitive behaviors** — hand flapping, body rocking, or spinning in circles.
- **Unusual play focus** — lines up objects or spins wheels rather than playing; distressed if order disrupted.
- **Sensory sensitivities** — extreme distress at everyday sounds; fascination with lights or spinning objects.

VISUAL QUICK REFERENCE — 6 KEY SIGNS (AGES 12–36 MONTHS)



⚠ The "Golden Rule" Red Flag (Any Age)

Any regression or loss of skills (speech, babbling, eye contact, gestures, or social abilities at any age) is a significant red flag requiring immediate developmental evaluation by a pediatrician.

STEP-BY-STEP PATH

How to Get Help: Screening & Evaluation

Follow this path to guide your family from initial concerns to accessing services.

1. **Observe & Track**
   Use the CDC "Learn the Signs. Act Early" milestone checklist. Note any concerns about speech, eye contact, play, or social engagement.

2. **Talk to Your Pediatrician**
   Request a formal developmental screening at the 18–month and 24–month well-child visits. Ask about the M-CHAT-R/F questionnaire.

3. **Get a Comprehensive Evaluation**
   If screening indicates risk, seek a full diagnostic evaluation from a developmental pediatrician, child psychologist, or multidisciplinary team.

4. **Access Early Intervention Services**
   Contact your local Infant & Toddler Connection (ages 0–3) or Child Find (ages 2–5). Early intervention is free and does not require a diagnosis to start. **No SSN required.**

LOCAL NORTHERN VIRGINIA (DMV) CONTACTS

Fairfax CSB — (703) 324-4400
Single most important number. No SSN required.

Child Find (FCPS)
Free screenings for children ages 20 months to 5 years.

Infant & Toddler Connection
Early intervention for ages 0–3 with developmental delays.

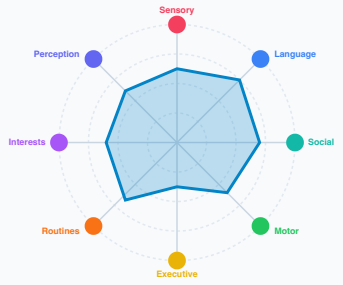
ASNV — (571) 328-5792
Autism Society of Northern Virginia.

SHIFTING PERSPECTIVES

The Autism Color Wheel & Spectrum

VISUALIZING NEURODIVERSITY

The Multidimensional Spectrum Wheel



Example of an individual's unique profile shape.

The scientific and autistic communities are shifting how they conceptualize autism. Instead of a linear scale from "mild" to "severe," autism is best understood as a **multidimensional color wheel**.

Each spoke represents a neurodevelopmental area: sensory sensitivity, language, social reciprocity, executive functioning, and more. An individual's profile forms a **unique shape** across these dimensions.

Key Takeaway: A child might need high support for sensory processing but have strong verbal skills. Another might show deep expertise in specialized interests while needing help in unstructured social settings. The wheel model recognizes each child's individual strengths.

OFFICIAL RESOURCES & PROJECT INFORMATION

Where to Learn More

OFFICIAL HEALTH RESOURCES

CDC — Screening for ASD — Monitoring guidelines.

CDC — Autism Spectrum Disorder — Resources & information.

CDC "Learn the Signs. Act Early" — Developmental checklist tracker.

NIH / NICHD: Autism & Early Intervention — Research-backed info.

Autism Speaks — Advocacy and support resources.

Autism Speaks 100-Day Kit — Step-by-step guide after diagnosis.

BILINGUAL & CULTURAL RESOURCES

Autism Speaks Chinese Toolkits — Downloadable guides translated into Chinese.

CARES (Chinese Autism Resources) — Peer support for Chinese families.

Infant & Toddler Connection (Fairfax) — Early intervention ages 0-3.

Child Find (FCPS) — Free developmental screenings, ages 20mo-5yr.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS

Autism: Myths vs. Clinical Facts

MYTH

"Autistic children cannot speak."

FACT

Autism is a broad spectrum. Many autistic children are highly verbal but need support with social reciprocity, routines, or sensory processing.

MYTH

"Wait and see if they outgrow it."

FACT

Early intervention during the critical brain development window (18-36 months) maximizes developmental gains. Waiting delays crucial support.

MYTH

"Autism is caused by poor parenting."

FACT

Autism is a genetic neurodevelopmental condition. Extensive global research has debunked any links to vaccines or parenting styles.

ABOUT THIS PROJECT

This pamphlet is part of Emma Zheng's initiative to increase early autism awareness among Chinese-speaking families in the DMV area and rural Hubei, China. Early diagnosis (between 18-36 months) is the single most critical factor in improving long-term developmental outcomes.

PRESENTATION VENUES

Hope Chinese School (HCS-TC) — Tyson's Corner Campus, Saturday/Sunday 2-4 PM parent break.

CCCVA Community — 541 Marshall Rd. SW, Vienna, VA 22180.

Request a Bilingual Presentation

Available for Chinese schools, church groups, clinics & community centers.

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Sources: NIH, CDC, ChildFind, Autism Speaks · Visit: emmaz-sv.github.io/early-autism-awareness